

Information Security Basics for All Employees

Why Security Is Everyone's Job

Most successful breaches do not begin with a technical exploit. They begin with an ordinary employee doing something reasonable in the wrong context: opening an attachment from a familiar name, reusing a password, or approving a login prompt they did not trigger.

This means security controls cannot be delegated entirely to the security team. The people best placed to notice that something is wrong are the people who know what normal looks like in their own work.

Recognising Phishing Attempts

A phishing message tries to make you act before you think. The three signals that matter most are urgency, an unexpected request for credentials or payment, and a mismatch between the display name and the actual sending address.

Hovering over a link reveals its true destination. Attackers rely on lookalike domains, where a single character is substituted, so the destination reads correctly at a glance but resolves elsewhere.

If a message appears to come from a colleague and asks for something unusual, verify through a different channel. Reply-to addresses can be controlled by the attacker, so replying to the message proves nothing.

Passwords And Multi Factor Authentication

Password length defeats brute force far more effectively than character substitution. A long passphrase of unrelated words is stronger and easier to remember than a short password with symbols substituted for letters.

Reuse is the more serious risk. When one service is breached, the credentials are tried automatically against every other well-known service, which is why a password manager with a unique value per site matters more than complexity rules.

Multi-factor authentication stops most credential attacks, but push notification fatigue is a real attack: an attacker who already has your password sends repeated prompts until one is approved out of irritation. An approval prompt you did not trigger should be denied and reported.

Handling Confidential Information

Information should be shared on the basis of need, not seniority. The question to ask before sharing is whether the recipient needs the information to do their job, not whether they are senior enough to see it.

Data that leaves a managed system stops being protected by it. Copying records into a personal spreadsheet, a personal email account, or an unapproved AI tool removes every control that applied to the original.

Reporting A Suspected Incident

Report early and imperfectly rather than late and completely. The cost of investigating a false alarm is small; the cost of a delay while an attacker is active compounds by the hour.

Do not attempt to investigate a suspicious message by clicking through it to see what happens. Preserve it, report it, and let the response team examine it in a controlled environment.